Aditi Thomas, a 39-year-old homemaker from Ahmedabad, still remembers with a shudder the horrific experience she and her husband had while travelling from Delhi to Jaipur on NH48 in their Innova. With the main highway jammed, they took a detour and were about to rejoin the highway when a speeding car hurtled into them and hit the driver's side. The airbags on the sides inflated, but her husband, who had been driving, still suffered bruises and whiplash symptoms, losing consciousness for a while. "It was the most frightening experience of my life," recalls Aditi. "I had a broken leg and was bleeding. I just did not know which number to dial for help." Unwilling to risk roadside healthcare and with no specialised trauma centre nearby, Aditi insisted they be taken to a hospital in Jaipur, since they were just 60 km away. It took her 15 minutes, that too with the help of bystanders, to find the number of the ambulance provider, another 45 minutes for the ambulance and the cops to arrive, 20 minutes of paperwork the cops insisted on and then an hour-long harrowing ride before they reached the Sawai Madho Singh Hospital in Jaipur.

Looking back, Aditi is grateful they escaped alive. Annually, Indian highways see over 100,000 fatalities in accidents. That is 274 deaths a day, or 11 every hour. Though national highways constitute barely 2.1 per cent of the 6.3 million km of road length in the country, they account for 36 per cent of the deaths and a third of the average 435,000 grievous injuries people suffer in road accidents. Add the state highways, and the figure goes up to over 60 per cent of deaths on just 5 per cent of total road length. "The problem is very, very serious," Nitin Gadkari, the Union minister of road transport and highways (MoRTH), tells INDIA TODAY (*see accompanying interview*). "Even when fighting extremist organisations or in a war, the death toll is much lower. Road accident deaths are among the top killers in India, up there with major diseases."

A 2020 study by IIT Delhi, 'The Socio-Economic Cost of Road Accidents in India', estimated that India loses some 3.14 per cent of its GDP in terms of human capital because of road accidents. This is because most of the victims are in the working age group of 18-60, and their death or injury entails loss of productivity, besides the cost of treatment and medicine, as well as out-of-pocket expenditure. In June, after resuming charge as the roads and highways minister, Gadkari in a meeting with senior officials reiterated India's commitment to meet the global target of reducing road crash deaths by 50 per cent by 2030. However, he is the first to admit that this is one area where he finds it difficult to meet the targets he has set because, as he says, "India has one problem other parts of the world do not have—there is neither respect for the law or the roads, nor fear of the law."

WHY INDIAN HIGHWAYS ARE UNSAFE

Be it reckless driving, lax enforcement of traffic rules, poor road and vehicle design or inadequate trauma care, accidents are only waiting to happen on Indian roads. According to a 2022 report released on the subject by the transport ministry, overspeeding alone was responsible for 75 per cent of the lives lost in highway crashes. However, as Piyush Tewari, co-founder of SaveLIFE Foundation, an NGO that has been working on road safety issues for the past 15 years, says, speed works in conjunction with other factors—the human error a high-speed vehicle becomes prone to, obstacles on the highway or another vehicle disobeying traffic rules. "You don't realise the role of other factors without scientific or forensic investigation of a crash," he says. "In most cases, the bigger vehicle is assumed to be at fault."

There are, in fact, five major factors that new research has shown to be responsible for road crashes and fatalities. These are:

- **Rank bad road sense of Indian drivers, who overspeed, drive on the wrong side and commit other violations**
- **Poor road engineering, including exposed concrete structures, extended drainage walls, missing crash barriers,**

274
Average number of deaths per day on Indian highways

60%
Share of deaths on highways, which account for 5% of the total road length

3.14%
Estimated loss to India's GDP due to road accidents and fatalities